

AUDIENCE INFLUENCE ON AR VS CC RIVALRY

KIN 7518

PRESENTATION 1

MADELEINE DURNIN, HAILEE HERNANDEZ, AND KAYLEE HOOPER



SOCIAL ISSUE CONTEXT & FRAMING

The rise of social media has significantly changed how athlete rivalries are constructed, especially through audience conversations on platforms like Instagram and YouTube. Angel Reese and Caitlin Clark have become two of the most visible athletes in women's basketball, and their rivalry has been heavily shaped by how audiences reference and frame them in comments and online discussions.



RESEARCH QUESTION

How do the frequency and framing of cross-athlete references in audience comments contribute to the perception of rivalry between Angel Reese and Caitlin Clark?

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

This issue matters because audience-driven rivalry narratives can influence athlete reputation, fan perception, and the overall growth and consumption of women's sports.



DATA & SCOPE

We utilized each of the ARCC Comment data files to encapsulate all sides of fan interaction and involvement towards the narrative

Instagram (2017-2024)

- 387,945 Combined Comments
 - 310,879 from Angel Reese's Posts
 - 77,066 from Caitlin Clark's Posts
- Direct Athlete-Audience Interaction

YouTube (2021-2024)

- 244,473 videos mentioning Angel Reese
- 507,859 videos mentioning Caitlin Clark
- 183,755 videos mentioning both athletes
- Third-Party Media Discourse

TOTAL

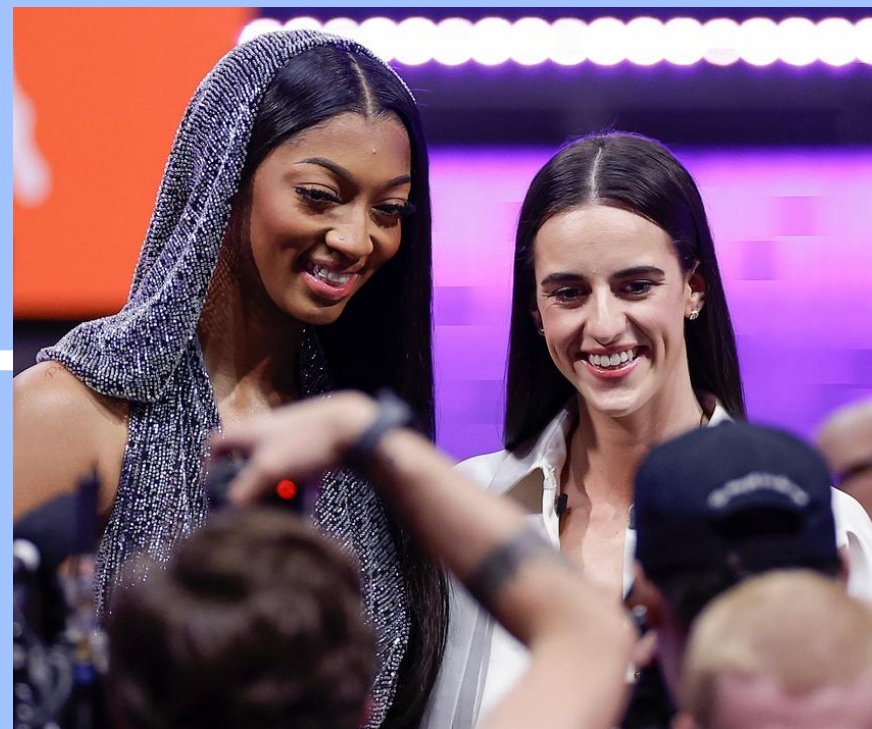
1,326,319 Comments across 2 platforms

ANALYTICAL STRATEGIES



Cross-Reference Detection

Use of Regex pattern matching to identify mentions of the opposite athlete



Framing Classification

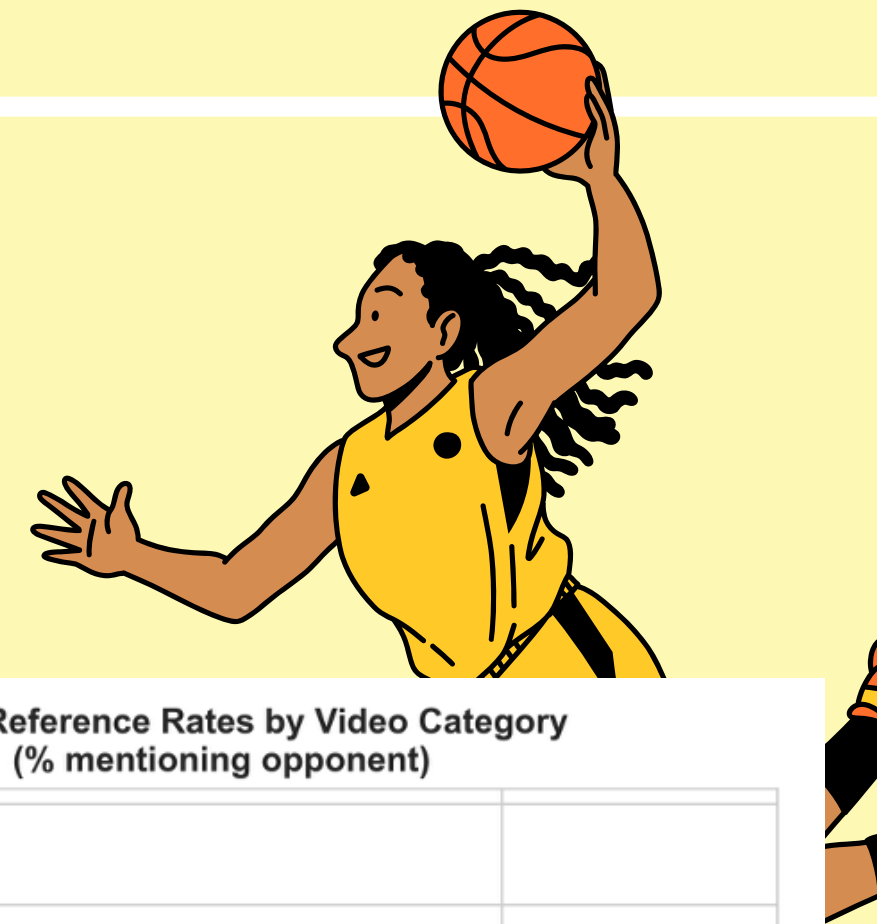
Keyword-based categorization into “competitive,” “dismissive,” “supportive,” and “comparative-neutral” frames



Sentiment Analysis

Dual scoring using VADER (social media optimized) and TexBlob for emotional tone

KEY FINDINGS



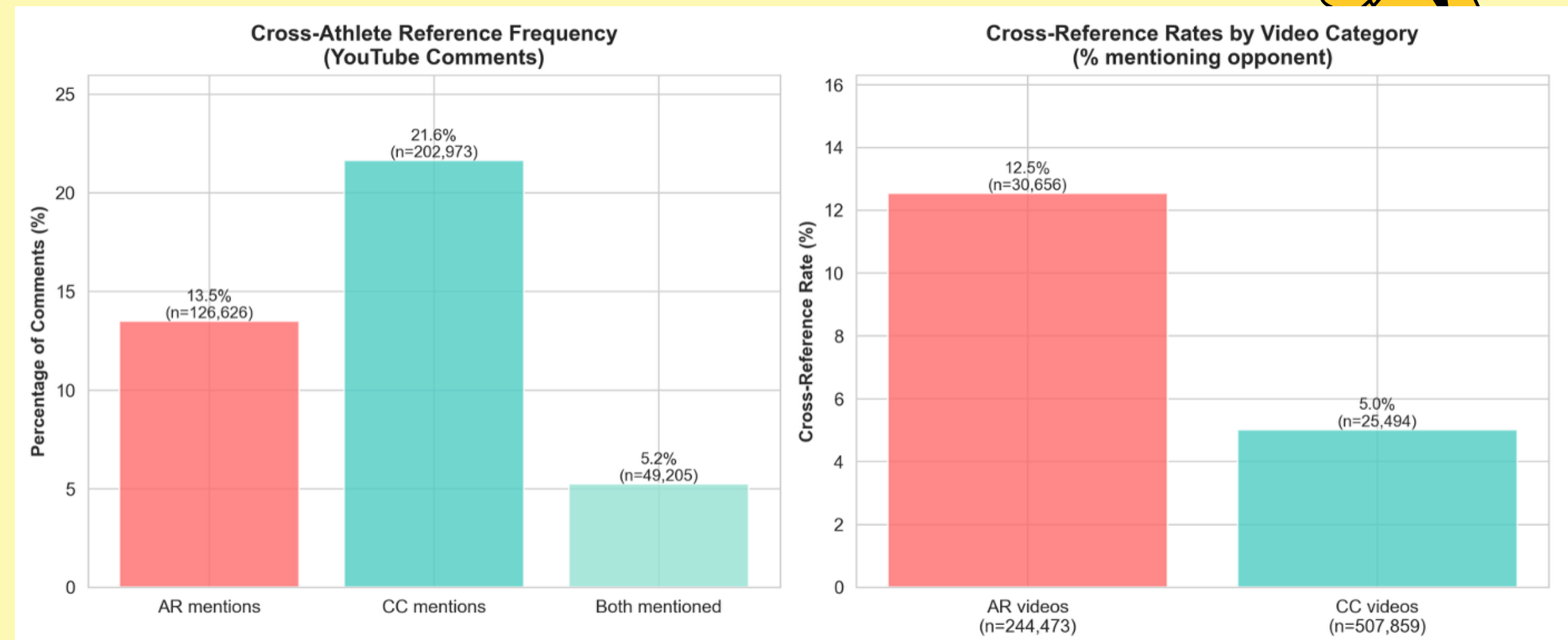
PLATFORM DIFFERENCES

YouTube shows 8-10x higher cross-reference rates than Instagram

- **Instagram:** 3.26% of comments mention CC, 4.71% mention AR
- **YouTube:** 21.63% of comments mention CC, 13.49% mention AR

YouTube exhibits more dismissive framing in cross-references

- **Instagram CC mentions:** 3.4% dismissive
- **YouTube CC mentions:** 9.3% dismissive
- **YouTube AR mentions:** 10.6% dismissive (highest)



→ YouTube discourse is significantly more rivalry-focused

KEY FINDINGS

FRAMING AMPLIFIES RIVALRY PERCEPTION

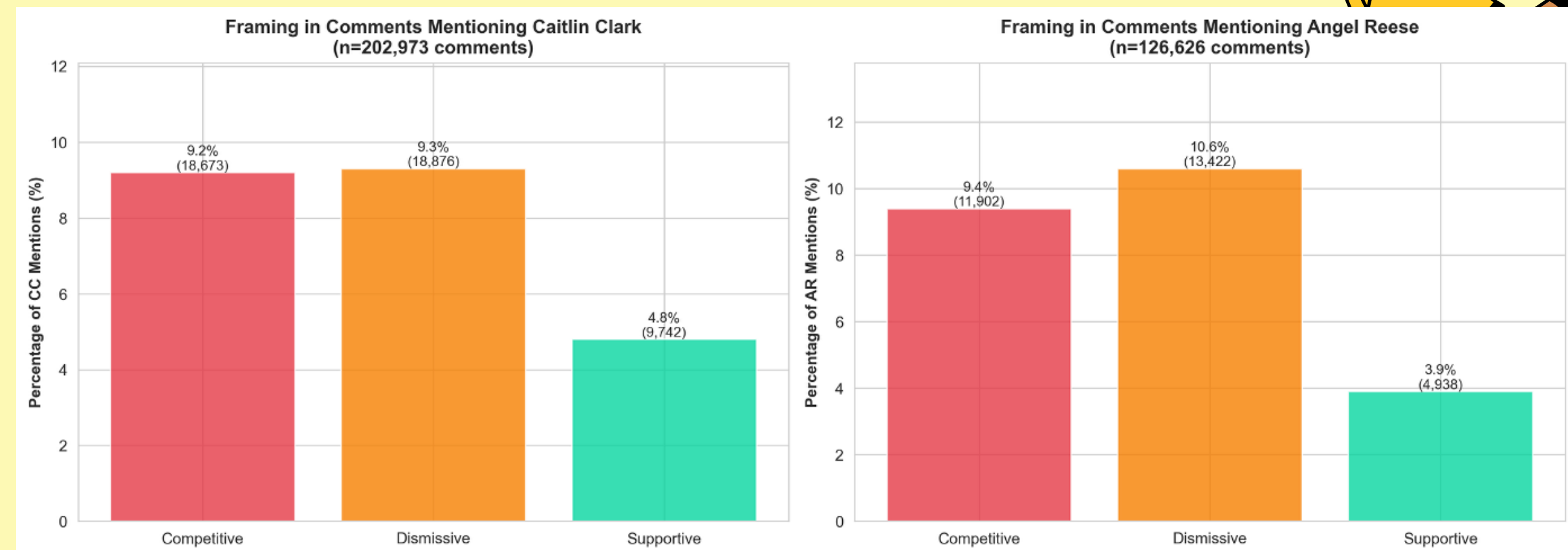
Cross-reference comments have 2-3x higher competitive/dismissive framing than general comments

Instagram cross-references (CC mentions)

- 6.7% competitive, 3.4% dismissive, 3.1% supportive

YouTube cross-references show more polarized framing

- **CC mentions** 9.2% competitive, 9.3% dismissive, 4.8% supportive
- **AR mentions** 9.4% competitive, 10.6% dismissive, 3.9% supportive



→ Framing matters beyond mere mention frequency



KEY FINDINGS

SENTIMENT & FRAMING

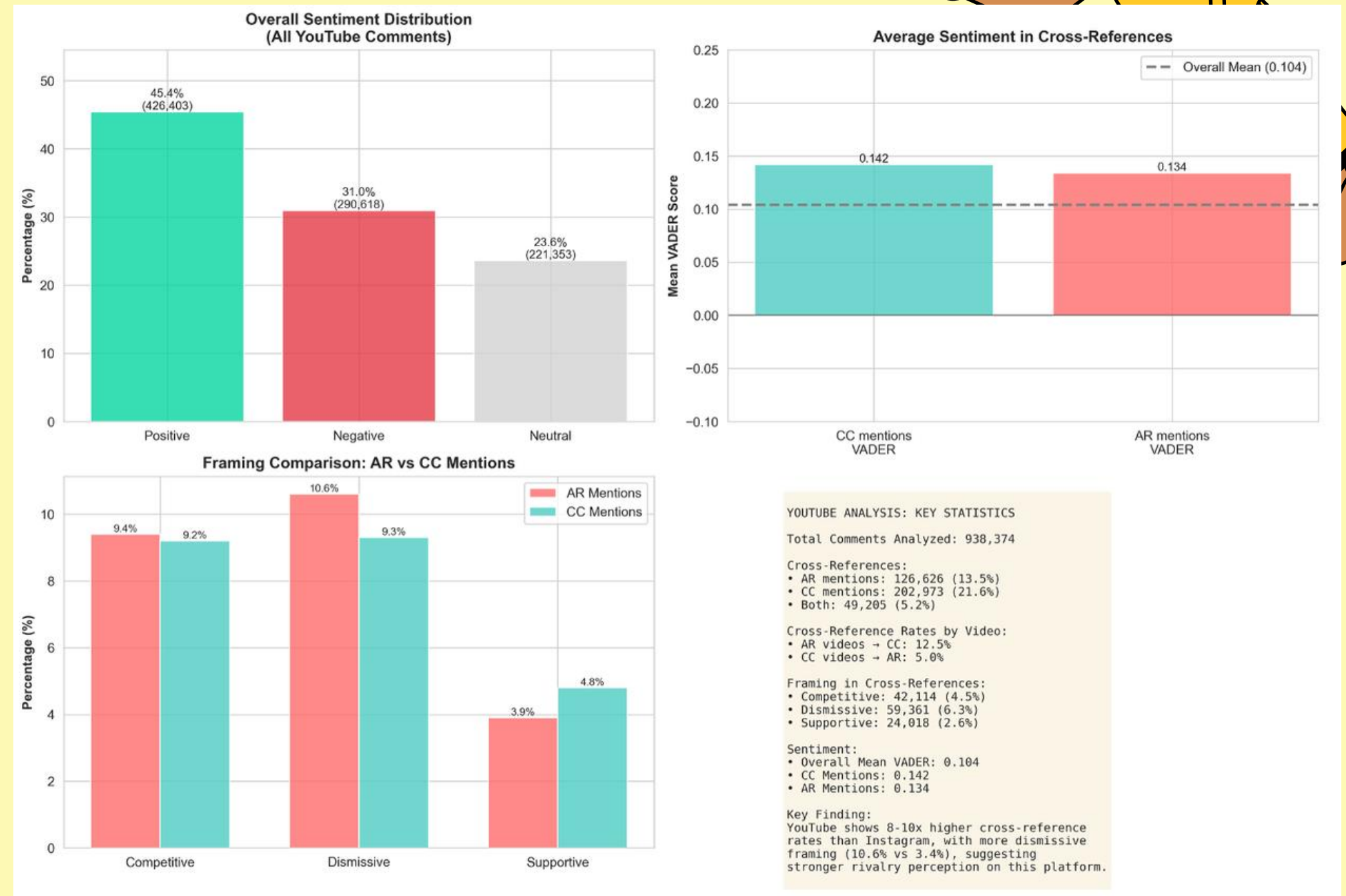
Despite competitive/dismissive framing, overall sentiment toward cross-references remains slightly positive

Instagram

- **CC mentions:** Mean VADER 0.287 (positive)
- **AR mentions:** Mean VADER 0.322 (positive)

YouTube:

- **CC mentions:** Mean VADER 0.142 (slightly positive)
- **AR mentions:** Mean VADER 0.134 (slightly positive)



→ Complex fan dynamics: rivalry coexists with appreciation for both athletes

INTERPRETATION: MEDIA FRAMING



Frequency + Framing = Rivalry Perception

High cross-reference rates (21.6% on YouTube) normalize comparative discourse.

Dismissive framing (9-11%) amplifies antagonistic narrative construction.



Platform Choice Matters

YouTube's third-party media context enables more overt rivalry framing.

Instagram's direct athlete-audience relationship constrains negative framing.



Racialized Framing Patterns

AR receives higher dismissive framing across platforms.

Aligns with broader patterns of differential treatment in women's sports media.

IMPLICATIONS

Our findings show that audience discourse plays a big role in shaping the perception between Angel Reese and Caitlan Clark. Platform differences can amplify rivalry narratives, as demonstrated especially on YouTube, with higher cross-reference rates and more competitive and dismissive framing. This suggests that social media audiences and third party media sources actively contribute to constructing and reinforcing the rivalry perception. Understanding how these narratives develop can help sport organizations, media professionals, and athletes better manage public perception and support the growth of womens sports.

